

The Universal Will

According to Schopenhauer, the world is experienced from outside as Representation, and from within as Will. The whole of what Kant had called the noumenal world, Schopenhauer said was characterized by Will. And because time and space do not exist in the noumenal realm, there can be no differentiation; the Will must be universal, indivisible and timeless, and therefore includes the Will present in every individual thing, including ourselves. Every individual's Will is part of the one Universal Will, which he saw as without consciousness or intelligence, impersonal and aimless. It is like a form of energy, controlling the world of Representation, including our basic urges and instincts. Schopenhauer believed that attempts to satisfy such desires are doomed to disappointment and frustration. The only hope of salvation is to give up any illusion of separation from the Universal Will, and any hope of gratification, and accept that one day we will not exist. This is strikingly similar to Hindu and Buddhist beliefs, which Schopenhauer later studied enthusiastically.



19th-century opium dens epitomised the hopelessness of seeking personal gratification.